

PRE-SOLICITATION NON-COMPETITIVE –

Notice of Intent to Sole Source

1. **SOLICITATION NUMBER:** 75N98026Q00234
2. **TITLE:** External Institutional Review Board (IRB) Services for Multi-Site Studies
3. **RESPONSE DATE:** May 5, 2026, at 9:00 am EDT.
4. **PRIMARY POINT OF CONTACT:**

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I. INTRODUCTION:

THIS IS A PRE-SOLICITATION NON-COMPETITIVE (NOTICE OF INTENT) SYNOPSIS TO AWARD A CONTRACT WITHOUT PROVIDING FOR FULL OR OPEN COMPETITION (INCLUDING BRAND-NAME).

The National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (NHLBI), Division of Intramural Research (DIR), requires continued Institutional Review Board (IRB) services to support ongoing multi-site clinical research studies conducted under Investigational Device Exemption (IDE) and Investigational New Drug (IND) protocols. These studies involve multiple participating sites and require centralized IRB oversight in accordance with NIH policy.

The NIH Intramural IRB is currently unable to serve as the IRB of record for certain NHLBI multi-site studies, including those with existing reliance on a commercial IRB and those requiring continuity through study closeout. As a result, NHLBI requires the services of an external IRB to ensure uninterrupted regulatory oversight, subject safety, and data integrity.

II. NORTH AMERICAN INDUSTRY CLASSIFICATION SYSTEM (NAICS) CODE and SET ASIDE STATUS

NAICS Code: **541990 – All Other Professional, Scientific, and Technical Services**
Size Standard: \$19.5 million

This acquisition is **not set aside for small business**.

III. REGULATORY AUTHORITY

The resultant contract will include all applicable provisions and clauses in effect through the Federal Acquisition Circular (FAC) 2024-07 dated 08-29-2024.

This acquisition is conducted under the procedures as prescribed in FAR Part 12—Acquisition of Commercial Products and Commercial Services and FAR Part 13—Simplified Acquisition Procedures.

IV. STATUTORY AUTHORITY

This acquisition is for a commercial service and is conducted under the authority of FAR 13.106-1(b)(1)—Only One Responsible Source and No Other Supplies or Services Will Satisfy Agency Requirements.

V. DESCRIPTION OF REQUIREMENT:

Purchase Description:

The Contractor shall provide IRB services on an as-needed basis, including but not limited to:

- Initial and continuing review of multi-site study protocols
- Review of investigators and sub-investigators
- Review of informed consent forms (ICFs), including site-specific language
- Review of recruitment materials and subject-facing documents
- Review of protocol amendments and modifications
- Review of reportable events requiring full board review
- Site closeout activities
- Administrative reviews and changes
- Emergency use reviews, as required

Salient Characteristics:

The required services must meet the following minimum characteristics:

- Ability to serve as the IRB of record for ongoing multi-site FDA-regulated clinical studies (IDE/IND)
- Capability to maintain continuity of IRB oversight for active protocols without disruption
- Existing infrastructure to support reliance agreements across multiple study sites
- Compliance with all applicable federal regulations, including 45 CFR 46 and 21 CFR 56
- Ability to support ongoing reporting, amendments, and closeout activities for studies currently under review
- Secure handling of sensitive human subjects research information

PERIOD OF PERFORMANCE:

June 1, 2026 – May 31, 2027

PLACE OF PERFORMANCE:

Services will be performed remotely via electronic communication between the Contractor and NHLBI personnel.

VI. CONTRACTING WITHOUT PROVIDING FOR FULL OR OPEN COMPETITION (INCLUDING BRAND-NAME) DETERMINATION

The Government intends to award a sole source contract to:

Advarra, Inc.

6100 Merriweather Drive, Suite 600
Columbia, Maryland 21044

This determination is based on the need for continuity of IRB oversight for ongoing multi-site clinical studies currently under review by Advarra. Transitioning to a different IRB provider at this stage would introduce unacceptable risks, including disruption to regulatory oversight, potential impacts to subject safety, and compromise of data integrity.

Existing reliance agreements and the history of oversight associated with these studies further necessitate continued use of the current IRB of record through study completion.

VII. CLOSING STATEMENT

THIS SYNOPSIS IS NOT A REQUEST FOR COMPETITIVE PROPOSALS. However, interested parties may identify their interest and capability to respond to this notice.

A determination by the Government not to compete this proposed contract based upon responses to this notice is solely within the discretion of the Government. All responsible sources may submit a capability statement, proposal, or quotation which shall be considered by the agency.

Responses must include sufficient detail to demonstrate the capability to meet the requirement and must include pricing information, delivery timelines, business size status, and proof of active SAM registration.

All responses must be received by the closing date and time of this announcement and must reference the solicitation number, **75N98026Q00234**. Responses must be submitted electronically to Nicholas Capobianco, Contract Specialist at nicholas.capobianco@nih.gov.